

as a lucid spinner of everyday stories are vividly demonstrated in the way we are lured to an increasing immersion in her triumphs and tribulations, as she juggles those who crowd her glass menagerie in her own ancestral Lilac House: her grandmother Lily, her mother Saro, and her own family comprising of her business magnate husband Giri and almost-grown-up children Nayantara and Nikhil. Nayantara, a delightful if difficult daughter now away studying at an IIT, is both Meera's bête noire and beloved, a daddy's girl who has as much trouble coping with his sudden departure as her mother does. *Lessons in Forgetting* opens with Meera, an immaculately-middle-aged corporate spouse who is a best-selling cookbook writer in her own right but is prouder still of being her man's appendage at endless cocktail parties, until abandoned at the end of one by her husband whose mid-life crisis spasms into a predictable pattern of deserting the familiar in search of greener (read younger) pastures.

Meera must take lessons in forgetting her distress at the humiliation of being discarded like a frayed and overused garment by the man she had unthinkingly invested her entire adult existence in. Jak must train himself to cope with the agony of a daughter lost to the vagaries of violence and fate, and to end his churning restless pursuit of the hidden truth behind what had

NAIR, IN AN EXPLORATION OF HUMAN LOVE AND SUFFERING, OFFERS US A PHILOSOPHY OF FORGETTING AS A SURVIVAL TRICK.

actually happened to Smriti the day her body was found broken and crushed by the sea in a small southern coastal town. But what he unearths is a lesson that we must not forget.

The still point of this quietly seething and simmering novel is a national shame, the business of medical clinics tucked in secluded alleyways that conduct illegal sex-determination tests and aid and abet the horror of female foeticide. So it is that Smriti, who courageously, if unwisely, rushes to uncover the terrifying truths that are hiding behind the grimy curtains of the "hospitals" in which such social sores fester and rot and spread, is sentenced to a screaming agonised death-in-life that becomes the axis upon which all Nair's lessons in remembering and forgetting turn. But amidst such convulsive grief does a frangible tenderness blossom between Jak and Meera, a frisson so fragile that we are loathe to disturb it even with hope. Here, indeed, is a novel well worth remembering. ■

TOP 10 A monthly list of national bestselling books compiled for INDIA TODAY by ORG-MARG

FICTION

1. *2 States: The Story of My Marriage*
Chetan Bhagat, Rupa
2. *Five Point Someone*
Chetan Bhagat, Rupa
3. *The Lost Symbol*
Dan Brown, Bantam Press
4. *The 3 Mistakes of My Life*
Chetan Bhagat, Rupa
5. *Ford County*
John Grisham, Arrow

NON-FICTION

1. *Discover the Diamond in You*
Arindam Chaudhuri, Vikas
2. *The Difficulty of Being Good: On the Subtle Art of Dharma*
Gurcharan Das, Penguin
3. *What the Dog Saw*
Malcolm Gladwell, Penguin
4. *Nine Lives: In Search of the Sacred in Modern India*
William Dalrymple, Bloomsbury
5. *Stay Hungry Stay Foolish*
Rashmi Bansal, CIEE, IIM-Ahmedabad

OTHER INDIAN BOOKS IN THE TOP 20

FICTION

8. *The White Tiger*
Aravind Adiga, HarperCollins
9. *Devil in Pinstripes*
Ravi Subramanian, Rupa
11. *Shantaram*
Gregory David Roberts, Penguin

NON-FICTION

7. *Don't Lose Your Mind, Lose Your Weight*
Rujuta Diwekar, Random House
8. *The Professional*
Subroto Bagchi, Penguin
11. *The Hindus: An Alternative History*
Wendy Doniger, Penguin

Participating bookshops: Delhi: Om Book Shop, Teksons, Land Mark, Crossword; Mumbai: Oxford, Shah Book Stall, Modern Book Shop; Bangalore: Gangarams, Land Mark; Hyderabad: Walden Book Link, The Book Point; Kolkata: Oxford Books, Modern Book Depot, Family Book Shop; Chennai: Land Mark

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